

INFORMATION FOR CHARLES · COOKIE POLICY

Cookie Policy

NamingContest.com · Last updated: October 1, 2026

This is information for Charles to create NamingContest's Cookie Policy. It is written as a complete draft from how the product works on October 1, 2026, and it is live on namingcontest.com until the reviewed version replaces it. After the policy comes an appendix with the facts about the product's data and tools, answered from the code. A few pain points worth a look are at the end.

This Cookie Policy explains how NamingContest.com, operated by The Cypher Group, LLC ("we", "us"), uses cookies and similar technologies, and how you can control them. It sits alongside our Privacy Policy, which explains how we handle personal information more broadly.

1. What cookies and similar technologies are

Cookies are small text files a website stores in your browser. Similar technologies include the browser's local storage and session storage. In this policy "cookies" covers all of them.

2. Cookies we use

Essential

These are needed for the website to work, so they do not need your consent.

NAME	PROVIDER	WHAT IT DOES	HOW LONG
sb-...-auth-token (local storage)	NamingContest (Supabase)	Keeps you signed in	Until you sign out
v4_... (local storage)	NamingContest	Saves an unfinished contest setup and your progress through a contest	Until cleared
nc_choice (local storage)	NamingContest	Remembers your cookie choice	Until cleared, or until we ask again
nc_region (session storage)	NamingContest	Remembers which country rules apply during this visit	Until you close the tab
__stripe_mid, __stripe_sid	Stripe	Fraud prevention on the payment form	Up to 1 year, and 30 minutes

Analytics

These help us understand how the website is used so we can improve it. Where the law requires it, they are only used with your consent.

NAME	PROVIDER	WHAT IT DOES	HOW LONG
<code>_ga,</code> <code>_ga_LLNNFFZGQH</code>	Google Analytics	Recognises a returning browser to count visits and the steps people complete	Up to 2 years
<code>_clck,</code> <code>_clsk</code>	Microsoft Clarity	Links page views into one session for recordings and heatmaps of clicks and scrolling. What you type is hidden.	Up to 1 year, and 1 day

Google Analytics and Microsoft Clarity are loaded through Google Tag Manager, which itself sets no cookies. Their advertising features are switched off. We also use Vercel Web Analytics, which counts page views without cookies and without identifying you. And we count the steps of contest setup anonymously in our own database (see the Privacy Policy); this uses no cookies and stores nothing on your device, so it runs whatever you choose.

3. How we ask for your choice

- **European Economic Area, United Kingdom and Switzerland:** a bar asks before any analytics cookie is used, with equal "Reject all" and "Accept all" buttons. Until you accept, analytics tools are not loaded at all. We find your country from your IP address. If it cannot be found, we ask.
- **Everywhere else:** analytics cookies are on by default, and you can turn them off at any time.

We keep an anonymous record of each answer to the bar (a random identifier stored only in your browser, your answer, the version of the bar, your country and the time) so we can show that consent was given.

4. Changing your mind

Choose Cookie settings in the footer of the website at any time to see your current choice and change it. If you turn analytics off, we delete the analytics cookies on our website and stop the tools straight away. You can also delete cookies or block them in your browser settings, though blocking essential ones may stop the website from working.

5. Changes to this policy

If we add new tools or uses, such as advertising, we will update this policy and ask for your choice again where the law requires.

6. Contact

Questions about cookies: hello@namingcontest.com. More about how we handle personal information is in our Privacy Policy.

APPENDIX · FACTS BEHIND THIS POLICY**FOR CHARLES · LEGAL PAGES INTAKE**

NamingContest.com: what data we collect and why

Facts taken from the code and settings of the live product as of October 1, 2026 (updated October 8, 2026 for the reporting dashboard and anonymous setup step counts), so the Privacy Policy, Cookie Policy and Terms can be written to match. Where something is a decision rather than a fact, it is marked as an open point.

Operator named in the current policies: The Cypher Group, LLC, 3645 Grand Avenue, Suite 206, Oakland, CA 94610, USA. Product: paid naming contests (USD 9, 19 or 39, one-time) where a host collects name ideas from invited people, who then vote.

01 Where are users located, and does GDPR apply?

- The site is in English, priced in US dollars and run from the US. Nothing blocks visitors from other countries, and hosts invite participants by sharing a link, so participants can be anywhere.
- Early visitors already include people in the EU.
- The site treats visitors from the EU, Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, the UK and Switzerland differently for cookies: analytics only loads after they agree. Location comes from the hosting provider's IP-based country lookup, and an unknown country is treated as European.
- Whether GDPR applies to the business as a whole (for example, whether it "offers services" to people in the EU) is your call.

02 Do voters need accounts?

- Yes. Everyone who submits or votes signs in with their email address. There are no passwords: the site emails a one-time sign-in link.
- Signing in creates an account holding the email address, a display name and an optional profile photo.
- Joining a specific contest happens through the host's invite link, and the person must be signed in to join.
- Hosts also sign in by email link, at the point of paying.

03 How do we prevent duplicate voting?

- One account per email address, and votes are tied to the account.
- The database refuses a vote unless the contest is in its voting stage and the person has joined that contest.
- Each person can pick at most 3 favourites per contest, the same name only once, and never their own submission.

- Each contest has a paid cap on participants (10, 30 or 90).
- There is no IP address check or device fingerprinting for votes. A person with several email addresses could join more than once, within the participant cap.

04 Do we track voters with IP addresses, browser fingerprints or cookies?

- **Fingerprinting:** none.
- **IP addresses, ours:** raw IP addresses are not stored. To stop abuse of a few public actions (the contact form, starting a contest, writing the brief), the server keeps a one-way hash of the IP address mixed with the date, which cannot be followed across days. It is used only to count requests per hour or day.
- **IP addresses, our providers':** the sign-in service (Supabase) records the IP address and browser of sign-in sessions in its own logs. The hosting provider (Vercel) sees IP addresses to serve pages and to look up the visitor's country. Stripe sees them at payment. Google Analytics and Microsoft Clarity see them when they are allowed to load.
- **Cookies:** the site's own features use the browser's local storage, not cookies. Cookies are set only by Google Analytics and Microsoft Clarity, after consent where required, and by Stripe on the payment form. Details are in section 08.

05 Which third-party tools are plugged in?

PROVIDER	WHAT IT DOES FOR US	WHAT IT RECEIVES
Supabase	Database, file storage, sign-in, server functions	All account and contest data in the table in section 07. Hosted in the United States (AWS US West, Northern California).
Vercel	Hosts the website; cookieless page statistics (Vercel Web Analytics); visitor country lookup	IP address and browser details of every page request; page views, referrer, country and device type for statistics, without cookies.
Stripe	Takes the contest payment	Card details entered directly into Stripe's form, the host's email (for the receipt), the amount and the contest id.
Resend	Sends email	Recipient email addresses and email content: sign-in links, "voting is open", winner announcements, contact form messages.
Anthropic (Claude)	Writes the contest brief from the host's answers	The host's answers to the brief questions, the contest name and the host's name (unless the host chose to stay anonymous). No email or account id. Their retention and training terms for API use should be checked against Anthropic's current commercial terms.

PROVIDER	WHAT IT DOES FOR US	WHAT IT RECEIVES
Google Tag Manager	Loads Google Analytics and Clarity	Loads only when analytics is allowed (see section 08).
Google Analytics 4	Visits and funnel steps (which steps of contest setup people finish, payments completed)	Pages viewed, events with the contest tier, category, step and contest id, device and approximate location. Our code sends no names, emails or answers. Advertising uses are switched off through Google Consent Mode.
Microsoft Clarity	Session recordings and heatmaps, to find confusing pages	Recordings of clicks, scrolling and page content. Clarity's "Balanced" masking hides what people type, including emails. Clarity's advertising use is switched off.
Google Search Console	Search performance in Google	Nothing from visitors. Google's own counts of searches, impressions and clicks for namingcontest.com.
Google Looker Studio	Internal reporting dashboard for the people who run the site	Reads Google Analytics, Search Console, a daily Clarity summary, and our database through a read-only login. That login can only see four reporting views of anonymous totals: contests by tier, category, price and date; counts of participants, suggested names and votes per contest; and the anonymous setup step counts. It cannot see names, email addresses, account ids, brief answers, suggested names or IP addresses. Contest and money figures come from the database, which counts every contest; Google Analytics is used for traffic only, because it sees only visitors who allow cookies.

Fonts are hosted on our own domain, so no font requests go to Google. Two leftover Google Fonts links were removed on October 1, 2026.

06 Payment gateway

- Stripe, using its embedded payment form. Card details go straight from the browser to Stripe and never touch our servers or database.
- We keep: whether the contest is paid, the price, and Stripe's payment reference. The receipt goes to the host's email from Stripe.
- One-time payment per contest. No subscriptions, no stored cards on our side.

07 What personal data we actually hold

DATA	ABOUT WHOM	WHY
Email address	Hosts and participants	Sign-in, receipts, contest emails (voting open, results). Not shown to other users: hosts do not see participants' emails.
Display name, optional photo	Hosts and participants	Shown next to their contest or their suggestions. Photos are stored in a public file bucket (anyone with the link can open them).
Brief answers and the written brief	The host, and often other people	Shown to participants so they can suggest names. Depending on the category this can describe a baby (due date, sibling names, family surname), a pet, a team, a band or a business.
Name suggestions and reasons	Participants	The contest itself. Each suggestion can be credited to the person or shown as anonymous, by their choice.
Votes	Participants	Which names a person picked, used to count results. Individual picks are not shown to the host.
Contest settings, dates, prize text	Hosts	Running the contest.
Payment status and Stripe reference	Hosts	Proof of payment.
Contact form messages	Anyone who writes in	Name, email, company, topic and message, emailed to the team. Not stored in our database.
Hashed request counters	Anyone using rate-limited actions	Abuse protection (section 04). Removed daily.
Cookie choice records	Anyone who answers the cookie bar	Proof of consent: a random id kept only in that browser, the answer, the bar version, the country and the time. No IP, email or account.
Anonymous setup step counts	Anyone going through contest setup	One row per step reached (tier, category, which brief question, time), so drop-off can be measured for every visitor. No id, IP, cookie or answer text; not tied to anyone. Counted whatever the cookie choice (added October 8, 2026).

08 Cookies, browser storage and the cookie bar

NAME	SET BY	PURPOSE	NEEDS CONSENT
Sign-in session (local storage, sb-...-auth-token)	Our site (Supabase)	Keeps the person signed in	No, essential

NAME	SET BY	PURPOSE	NEEDS CONSENT
Drafts and progress (local storage, v4_...)	Our site	Saves an unfinished contest setup and contest steps	No, essential
Cookie choice (local storage, nc_choice)	Our site	Remembers the visitor's answer	No, essential
Beta access (local storage, nc_beta_ok_v3)	Our site	Pre-launch password gate, removed at launch	No, essential
__stripe_mid, __stripe_sid	Stripe	Fraud prevention on the payment form	No, essential for payment
_ga, _ga_LLNNFFZGQH	Google Analytics	Recognise a returning browser for visit statistics	Yes
_clck, _clsk	Microsoft Clarity	Link page views into one recorded session	Yes

How the cookie bar behaves

- **EU, Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, UK, Switzerland, or unknown country:** a bar asks first, with "Reject all" and "Accept all" as identical buttons side by side. Until the visitor accepts, Google Tag Manager, Google Analytics and Clarity do not load and set no cookies.
- **Everywhere else:** analytics loads by default with no bar.
- **Changing your mind:** "Cookie settings" in the footer, on the copyright line under the Legal column, reopens the bar. Turning analytics off deletes its cookies and stops it straight away. Analytics cookies left from visits before the bar existed are deleted for anyone who has not said yes.
- One choice covers both analytics tools, because both serve one purpose: understanding how the site is used. Advertising uses are switched off today. If ads are added, the bar gains a separate advertising choice and asks everyone again.
- Tested on October 1, 2026 with an automated browser that logged every request and cookie in each case above.

Bar wording today: *"We use essential cookies to run the site, such as keeping you signed in. With your permission, we would also like to use analytics cookies from Google Analytics and Microsoft Clarity to understand how the site is used, including session recordings, so we can improve it. You can change your choice at any time under Cookie settings in the footer."* Its one link goes to the Cookie Policy, so that page should name the company running the site and link to the Privacy Policy. The Terms of Service are left off the bar on purpose, so consent never looks tied to accepting terms. Please adjust as needed.

Worth a look

A few pain points we noticed while writing this, to keep in mind rather than a checklist. If anything is unclear, or you need more detail on any part of the product, just ask.

- **Cookies we use** (section 2). Durations are the providers' published defaults. Worth checking them against each provider's current documentation.
- **Future advertising.** Meta and Google Ads may be added later. That would mean a separate advertising choice in the cookie bar, advertising cookies or pixels, and likely a "Do Not Sell or Share" link plus updated notices for US state laws. The bar is versioned so everyone can be asked again.